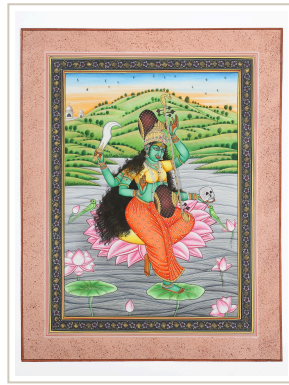


TANTRAYA

Supplementary Workbook · The Ten Mahavidyas

Matangi

Mistress of Speech and Sound



Matangi, green-complexioned, seated with veena and lotus, mistress of sound, speech, and the outcast places

Ninth of the Mahavidyas · The Outcast Wisdom

Sovereign of vak, speech and sound, mistress of vashikarana, she who honors the polluted and the discarded

Learning to speak, listen, and create from what is genuine rather than what is merely acceptable

Tantraya · Sacred Valley of Peru

At a Glance

RANK	Ninth of the ten Mahavidyas
NAME MEANS	Of the Matanga, the outcaste or elephant-keeper community; also read as the great, boundless one, related to matanga, elephant, and to unrestrained wildness
FORM	Green or dark-emerald complexioned, seated, holding a veena and often a parrot, sometimes shown eating from or accepting leftover, half-eaten offerings
VEHICLE / EMBLEMS	Veena for sacred sound and music, parrot for eloquent speech, leftover or polluted offerings accepted without hesitation as her particular sign
KARMA / ACTION	Vashikarana, attraction: drawing another toward you through the specific power of genuine voice, sound, and presence rather than through manipulation
FOCUS OF THESE PRACTICES	Finding and speaking your own genuine voice, and honoring what has been rejected as impure or unworthy in yourself and in the world

The Myth

Matangi's origin is closely tied to the sage Matanga, who is said to have performed severe austerities in the hope of gaining power over even Indra, king of the gods. His penance succeeded in some respects but not entirely, and out of the residue of that vast, unfinished austerity, the goddess Matangi arose, embodying both the power the sage sought and the parts of existence his penance had not been able to purify or control. She is, in this telling, the goddess of what remains ungovernable even by the greatest human effort at mastery and purity.

A second and equally important strand of her mythology places her explicitly among the outcastes, the Matanga community whose traditional work involved handling what caste society considered polluting, the bodies of the dead, discarded food, refuse. Where the wider culture around her worship built an elaborate structure of purity and pollution,

Matangi is worshipped specifically as the goddess who refuses that structure's authority. She is offered food already eaten by others, leftovers, the polluted, the rejected, and she receives these offerings not as a lesser form of worship but as her preferred one, because they represent exactly what conventional purity has decided has no value.

In the broader Devi tradition, Matangi is closely associated with Saraswati, the goddess of learning, speech, and the arts, and is sometimes described as her tantric or wilder counterpart. Where Saraswati governs refined, cultivated knowledge and eloquence, Matangi governs speech and sound in their rawer, less domesticated form, including the speech and expression of those the wider culture has decided are unworthy of a cultivated voice at all.

Symbolism and Image

Every element of Matangi's image works to elevate exactly what conventional society treats as impure, discarded, or beneath serious regard. Her green complexion associates her with nature in its untamed rather than cultivated form, wildness rather than the manicured garden. Her veena, an instrument of extraordinary sophistication and refinement, held by a goddess otherwise associated with outcastes and leftovers, deliberately collapses the assumed link between social status and genuine artistic or spiritual mastery.

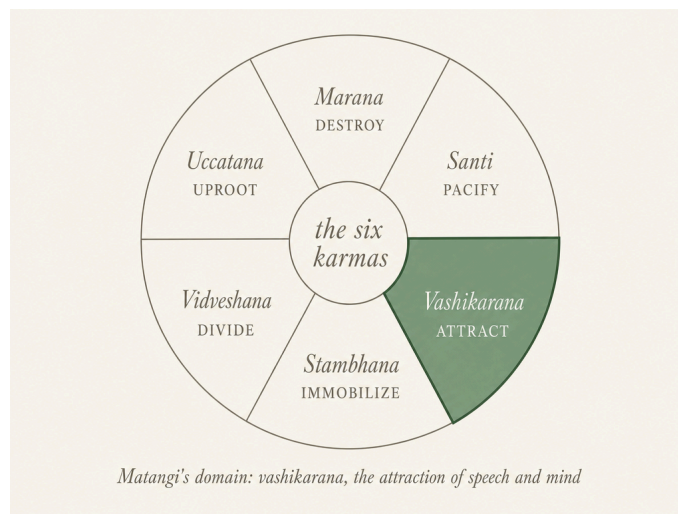
Her acceptance of half-eaten and polluted offerings is her most distinctive and, to newcomers, most startling feature. It is not a sign of degradation. It is a direct, embodied teaching: that which a rigid system of purity has rejected as worthless very often contains exactly the power and vitality that system has spent its energy trying to exclude. Matangi does not merely tolerate what has been rejected. She actively prefers it, and finds in it a potency the cultivated and acceptable version has already lost.

Her parrot, an animal famous for its capacity to speak without necessarily originating what it says, points toward a subtlety in her teaching about speech itself. Much of ordinary human speech is, in fact, closer to the parrot's: repetition of what has been heard, socially acceptable phrasing, words chosen for how they will be received rather than because they are genuinely true for the speaker. Matangi's deeper teaching about vak, speech, is the cultivation of the rarer kind, speech that actually originates from direct, genuine presence rather than simply repeating what is expected.

Understanding the Energy

Among the six classical tantric actions, pacifying, attracting, immobilizing, dividing, uprooting, and destroying, Matangi is most closely associated with vashikarana, attraction, though her particular expression of it is distinct from the more commonly taught forms. Her attraction does not work through charm deployed strategically or through manipulation of another's desire. It works through the sheer, undeniable power of genuine voice and presence, speech and sound that comes from an unguarded, authentic place rather than a calculated one.

Most people's speech and self-presentation is heavily filtered for social acceptability long before it reaches another person, which is precisely why so much ordinary communication fails to actually move or attract anyone in a lasting way. Matangi's current works by removing that filter, allowing what is genuinely present in a person, including the parts of themselves they have been taught are unacceptable, impure, or unworthy of expression, to become audible and visible. What attracts, in her current, is never the polished performance. It is the presence of something real.



Matangi's domain among the six karmas: vashikarana, attraction through genuine voice

This is why her practices, done honestly, often involve reclaiming exactly what a student has learned to consider unacceptable about their own voice, their own history, their own manner of speaking or creating. What they train is not eloquence in the conventional sense but authenticity of expression, the capacity to let sound and speech arise from what is actually true rather than from what has been rehearsed for acceptability. Matangi does not teach a technique for becoming more persuasive. She restores contact with the register of voice that was always more powerful than persuasion.

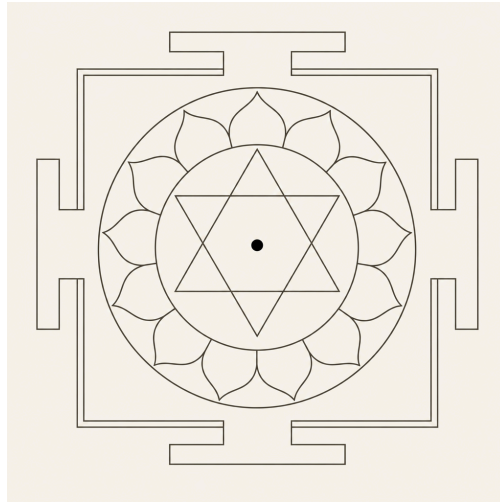
How to Work With These Practices

Matangi's practices work directly with voice, sound, and the parts of yourself or your history you have learned to consider unacceptable, impure, or beneath expression. This will surface material that feels, at times, genuinely uncomfortable to bring into the open.

None of this is about being deliberately crude, offensive, or performatively transgressive for its own sake. The aim is authenticity, not shock. If a practice starts to feel like you are performing rebellion rather than speaking from something genuinely true, return to the plainer, quieter version of your own real voice.

Move through these in order. Each isolates a different place genuine voice tends to be filtered out, speech, creative expression, the rejected parts of your own history, listening, and finally presence itself, so that by the seventh you are working directly with what actually attracts and moves others, and yourself.

Practices



The Matangi Yantra: bhupura and lotus petals holding the central triangle of voice and sound

Matangi is not approached through learning a technique of eloquent or persuasive speech. She is approached through the more demanding practice of letting your actual voice, including its rejected, unpolished, or unacceptable elements, become audible rather than filtered.

Each practice below isolates a different place this filtering usually happens without your noticing. By the seventh they converge on the same recognition every serious student of this current eventually reaches: what you had been taught was too raw, too odd, or too unacceptable to express was very often the exact thing that, once spoken, actually reached people.

Practice One – The Unfiltered Sentence

Practice. Several times today, before speaking, notice the filtering your mind normally applies, softening, qualifying, choosing the acceptable phrasing over the true one, and once, in a low-stakes moment, let the unfiltered version out instead. Notice what happens when you speak the more direct, less curated sentence.

Evening reflection. What did I discover when I let an unfiltered sentence out instead of the managed version I usually reach for?

Practice Two – Reclaiming the Rejected

Practice. Identify one part of your history, manner of speaking, accent, background, or way of expressing yourself that you learned early to consider unacceptable or embarrassing. Today, let that part be present and visible in some small, deliberate way rather than hidden or apologized for.

Evening reflection. What did it feel like to let that rejected part of myself be visible today, rather than managed out of sight?

Practice Three – Sound Without Words

Practice. Spend fifteen minutes making sound, humming, singing, chanting, or simply vocalizing, without any concern for whether it is musical, correct, or pleasant to hear. Let the sound come from wherever it actually wants to come from in your body, rather than from an idea of how it should sound.

Evening reflection. What did I notice about the sound that came out once I stopped managing how it should sound?

Practice Four – Listening to the Discarded

Practice. Today, deliberately give real attention to something or someone your surroundings usually treat as unworthy of notice, a person often overlooked, a piece of music considered unrefined, a story usually dismissed as unimportant. Listen to it as though it might contain something genuine that more acceptable things have lost.

Evening reflection. What did I find of genuine value in what I usually pass over as unworthy of real attention?

Practice Five – Creating From the Unpolished

Practice. Make something today, write, draw, cook, arrange, and deliberately resist the urge to polish or perfect it before sharing or finishing it. Let the first, rawest version stand as the completed thing, and notice what is lost and what is gained by not refining it further.

Evening reflection. What was actually present in the unpolished version of what I made today that a polished version might have smoothed away?

Practice Six – Speaking the True Need

Practice. Identify one place today where you are inclined to phrase a need or request in the most socially comfortable way possible, and instead state the actual, specific truth of what you need, even if it feels more exposed or less polite than your habitual phrasing.

Evening reflection. What changed in the interaction once I spoke the actual need rather than its more comfortable phrasing?

Practice Seven – Presence Without Performance

Practice. Choose one interaction today and enter it with the specific intention of being genuinely present rather than presenting a version of yourself calculated to be well received. Notice the difference between the pull to perform and the quieter, less guarded experience of simply being present as you actually are.

Evening reflection. What was the difference today between the moments I was performing and the moments I was simply, genuinely present?

Advanced Exercises

The Discarded Offering. Set aside something ordinarily thrown away or overlooked, a wilted flower, a leftover meal, an unfinished thought, and treat it deliberately as an offering worthy of attention, in the spirit of Matangi's own preference for what has been rejected.

Voice Recording. Record yourself speaking honestly about something you normally soften or avoid, then listen back. Notice what your actual voice sounds like when it is not managing its own reception.

The Veena Hour. Spend an hour with any instrument or sound-making object, even improvised, exploring sound purely for its own sake, without any goal of producing something recognizably musical or correct.

Speaking to the Overlooked. Have a genuine conversation with someone whose voice is often talked over, dismissed, or unheard in your usual circles, and give them your full, undivided attention.

The Hidden Curriculum

Students working through this material typically begin believing Matangi teaches eloquence or the cultivation of a more attractive way of speaking. What they usually discover instead is closer to the opposite. What actually attracts, moves, and reaches other people is very rarely the most polished or socially acceptable version of a voice. It is the version that has stopped filtering itself for acceptability and is simply, finally, genuinely present.

The Deeper Principle

Every tradition that takes voice and expression seriously eventually arrives at some version of the recognition Matangi embodies directly: authenticity has a power that persuasion, however skillfully deployed, does not. Matangi does not ask a student to become more eloquent in the conventional sense. She reveals that what a rigid system of acceptability has taught them to consider unworthy of expression, their raw voice, their rejected history, their unpolished sound, is very often exactly what carries the power that the cultivated version has already lost.

Her Faculty

If each Mahavidya develops one irreplaceable human capacity, Matangi's is best called authentic voice: the capacity to speak, create, and be present from what is genuinely true rather than from what has been filtered for acceptability. This capacity underlies every act of expression that actually reaches another person, rather than merely performing adequately for them.

This is a demanding capacity to reclaim, because so much of a person's expressive life has been quietly trained, from early childhood onward, toward acceptability rather than authenticity. Matangi does not ask a student to abandon all discernment about what and how they express. She restores their access to the register beneath the filtering, the genuine voice a system of purity and acceptability had taught them was unworthy of being heard at all.